HOW TO FIX IT

- Accelerate the momentum for local advocacy programmes through gram panchayats to gain buy-in and acceptance of the scheme at the grassroots level
- Involve third-party agents to help interns with expectation-setting and handhold them while applying for job positions
- Increase monthly stipend of Rs 5,000, particularly for youth who have to relocate to a city for work. Companies may consider paying a reasonable amount that covers the cost of living
- Make eligibility criteria more open by reducing the lower age limit to 18 instead of 21 and remove upper age limit
- Keep the portal open for longer durations, or even continuously, so companies can apply when they want and HR teams don't feel pressured
- Make duration of internship flexible. For instance, internships in retail do not need to last a full year; 3-6 months can suffice. Manufacturing internships, on the other hand, can be for 12 months

RESTRICTIVE ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA: Only youth aged 21-24 years, who have passed high school, hold an ITI certificate, diploma from a polytechnic, or a graduate degree (BA, BSc, BCom, BCA, BBA, BPharma, etc.) can apply for PMIS, provided they are unemployed, not studying full-time, and their yearly family income is below Rs 8 lakh. Not many people make the cut, reducing the number of applicants.

SCHEME OVERLAP: Some experts question the very rationale of creating a parallel ecosystem when there are already several similar skilling schemes, such as the National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme (NAPS), the National Apprenticeship Training Scheme (NATS) and the Dual System of Training (DST). "Why have so many schemes for the same purpose of skilling—making youth employable?" asks Gupta of JustJobs Network. "NAPS, NATS and DST may focus on different youth cohorts, but they all aim to improve employability through hands-on training." In its defence, the government says schemes like NAPS and NATS are mandatory by law for certain companies and the PMIS (a voluntary scheme) intends to go beyond them.

EXPECTATION MISMATCH: With no third-party associates or agents to handhold them through the process, candidates often misunderstand job expectations. "We've seen them apply for a role only to realise later that it requires relocation," says Nipun Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Degree Apprenticeship. They also don't know what to expect from a corporate job. Like the fact that an assembly-line role may require standing up to eight hours a day. Emphasising the role of awareness and advocacy, Aman Pannu, president of the DCM Shriram Foundation, says, "For any positive social change, building collective consciousness is a must. Mindset change needs to be strengthened if a scheme is to make an impact at the grassroots." The reason her firm's CSR skilling projects in Hardoi and Lakhimpur, Uttar Pradesh, have a retention rate of 85 per cent, Pannu explains, is that their implementation agency at the grassroots mobilises the youth, involves parents, gets their buy-in and also explains the candidate's earning trajectory in advance.

BURDEN OF COMPLIANCE: Participating companies have their own set of issues, starting with creating a PMIS cell within the organisation. They are also unhappy with the PMIS digital portal, the base for end-to-end implementation. It is open only during specific periods, and they have to post internship positions in that time, placing an unnecessary burden on HR teams. Companies have to post opportunities on the dashboard, candidates have to register on the portal and apply for internships based on their preferences and eligibility. They, in turn, shortlist and make internship offers, which candidates must accept or reject within two weeks.

To add to their woes, every organisation must fill out assessments for each applicant. "We had to fill out details for 2,500 applicants," says one HR head. The government has also mooted a quota for SCs/STs, which promises to add to the burden.

MAKING A FRESH START

Poor joining rates remain a persistent bugbear for companies, even when they have created positions specifically for NEET youth, a point industry executives raised at a meeting organised by the MCA in Delhi on September 15. Several companies have suggested that instead of relying solely on the online portal, they should be allowed to hire PMIS interns directly from campuses. Their rationale? Face-to-face interactions could improve joining rates and help set expectations right from the start.

CIEL HR's Mishra also suggests increasing the stipend amount as it is not financially viable, especially for interns in urban areas. A Pre-Placement Offer (PPO) mechanism could also improve the scheme's appeal.

The MCA itself is considering a few course-corrections, like keeping the portal open throughout the year, improve the interface, launching a mobile app and adding geotagging for location-based choices. The MCA is also considering enrolling companies outside the top 500.

There is no denying the potential or the intent of the initiative. However, its weak start has laid bare structural gaps. Unless these are fixed, PMIS risks becoming another government scheme backed by a massive budget but failing to deliver meaningful impact. ■